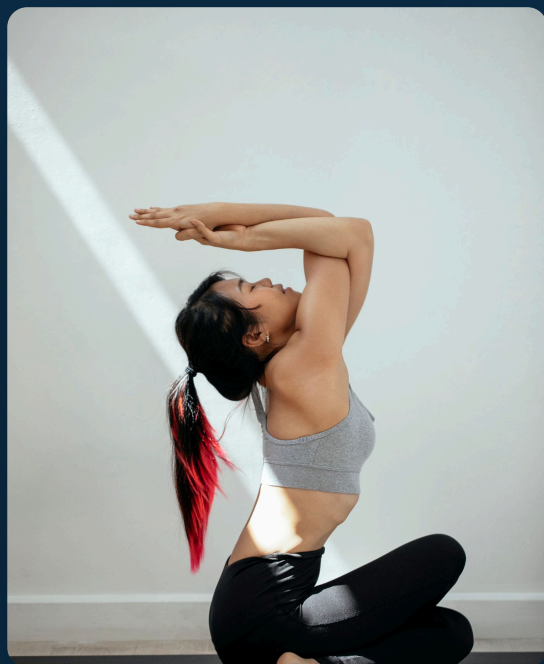


The Pain-Free Workday Blueprint

Desk-worker edition



A practical, hour-by-hour system to protect your back, neck and joints — built for people who sit for a living.



Inside

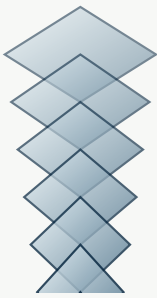
30+

pages of routines, diagrams & printables

Daily time needed

10 min

How to use this guide



Read · Try · Track



(01)

Read the why

Sections 01–02 explain what sitting does to your body and how to fix your setup in 15 minutes.

(02)

Run the day

Section 03 gives you an hour-by-hour plan. Follow it for one normal workday first.

(03)

Track 14 days

Use the printable tracker and journal at the back. Small daily wins compound fast.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

- ✓ A chair and desk you already own
- ✓ A towel or small cushion
- ✓ 10 minutes a day
- ✓ A printer (optional)

Quick self-check

Score yourself

- | | | |
|----|---|--|
| 01 | I sit for more than 6 hours on most workdays | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 02 | I often end the day with a stiff neck or shoulders | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 03 | My lower back aches after long sits | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 04 | I rarely take a break in the first 2 hours of work | ☐ Yes ☐ No |
| 05 | My screen sits below eye level (laptop on the desk) | ☐ Yes ☐ No |

0–1 yes: fine-tune · 2–3 yes: start the 14-day plan · 4–5 yes: start today

IMPORTANT — PLEASE READ

This guide is for general education and wellbeing. It is not medical advice and does not diagnose or treat any condition. Stop any movement that causes sharp pain. If you have an existing injury, recent surgery, are pregnant, or have symptoms like numbness, weakness or pain that won't settle, talk to a doctor or physiotherapist before starting.

Table of

08 chapters



Start anywhere. If you only have five minutes today, jump straight to the Micro-Break Library on page 16.

(001)	The Desk Problem	05
(002)	Your Body at the Desk	06
(003)	Workstation Setup	09
(004)	The Hour-by-Hour Blueprint	13

(005)	Micro-Break Library	16
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(006)	Targeted Routines	18
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(007)	Recovery at Home	23
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(008)	Your 14-Day Plan	28
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Content

The Desk Problem

Why it hurts



People living with low back pain (2020)

619M

Projected by 2050

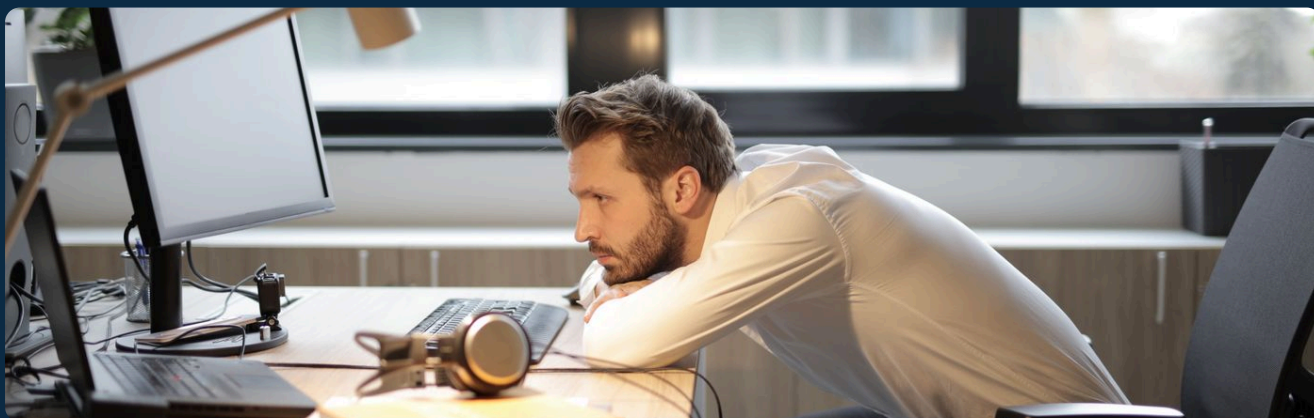
843M

Global rank of low back pain as a cause of disability

#1

Extra load on your neck at a 60° head tilt

~5x



Our bodies are built to move, but modern work asks them to hold one shape for hours. The result isn't one dramatic injury — it's a slow build-up of stiffness that turns into everyday pain.

Sources: GBD 2021 Low Back Pain Collaborators, *The Lancet Rheumatology* (2023); World Health Organization, Low back pain fact sheet (2023); Hansraj, *Surgical Technology International* (2014).

Your Body at the Desk

Six pressure points take most of the load during a seated workday.

Neck

Forward head posture loads the cervical spine

Shoulders

Tension from raised, rounded shoulders

Wrists

Repetitive typing and mouse strain

Lower back

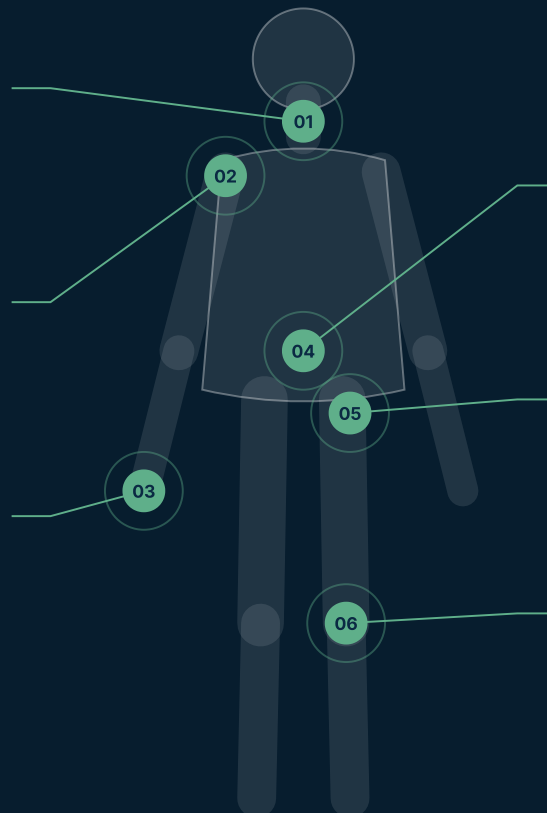
Sitting flexed flattens the lumbar curve

Hips

Hip flexors shorten in long sits

Knees

Stiffness from staying bent for hours



Hotspots

6

Most common complaint

Lower back

Best fix for all six

Movement

The loop that keeps you sore



Break the loop early

The easiest place to interrupt the cycle is step 001. A 2-minute movement break every 30 minutes stops fatigue from ever building.

KEY IDEA

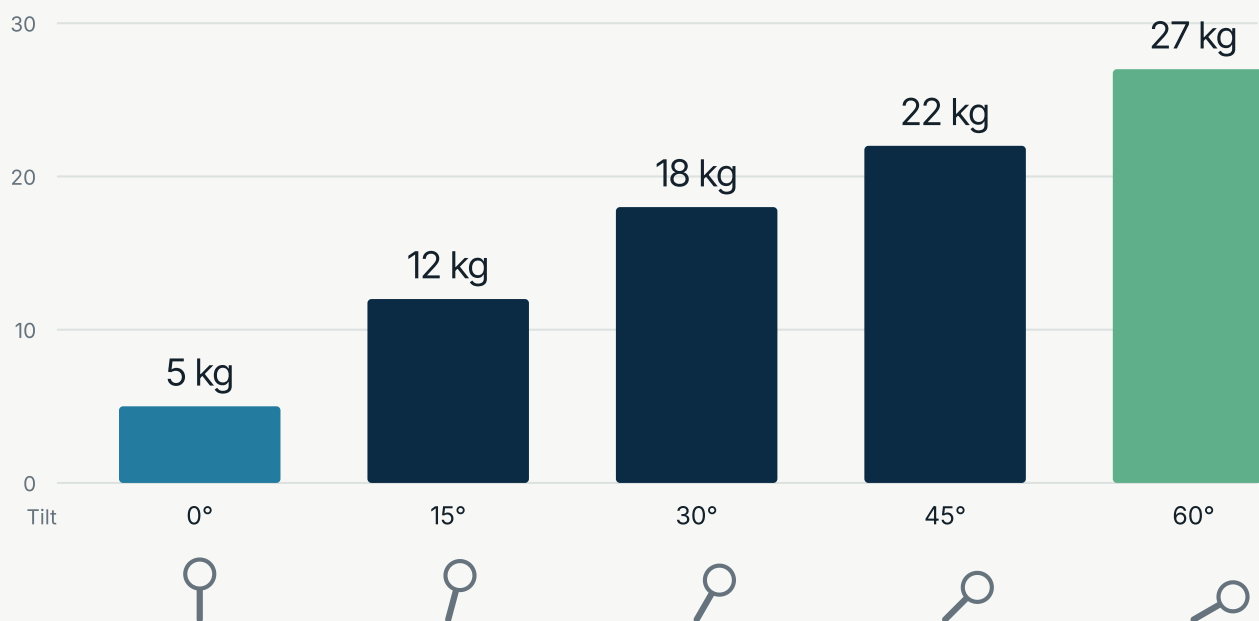
Your next posture is your best posture. No single "perfect" position beats changing position often.

Tech Neck, Measured

Head-tilt load



An adult head weighs about 5 kg upright. Tilt it forward to look at a phone or low laptop screen, and the effective load on your neck multiplies.



Fix 01

Raise the screen

Laptop on a stand or books, with an external keyboard.

Fix 02

Phone to eyes

Lift your phone, don't drop your head.

Fix 03

Chin tucks

10 reps, twice a day (page 18).

Source: Hansraj KK. Assessment of stresses in the cervical spine caused by posture and position of the head. *Surgical Technology International*, 2014. Values rounded.

Workstation Setup

15-minute fix



Time to fix your setup

15 min

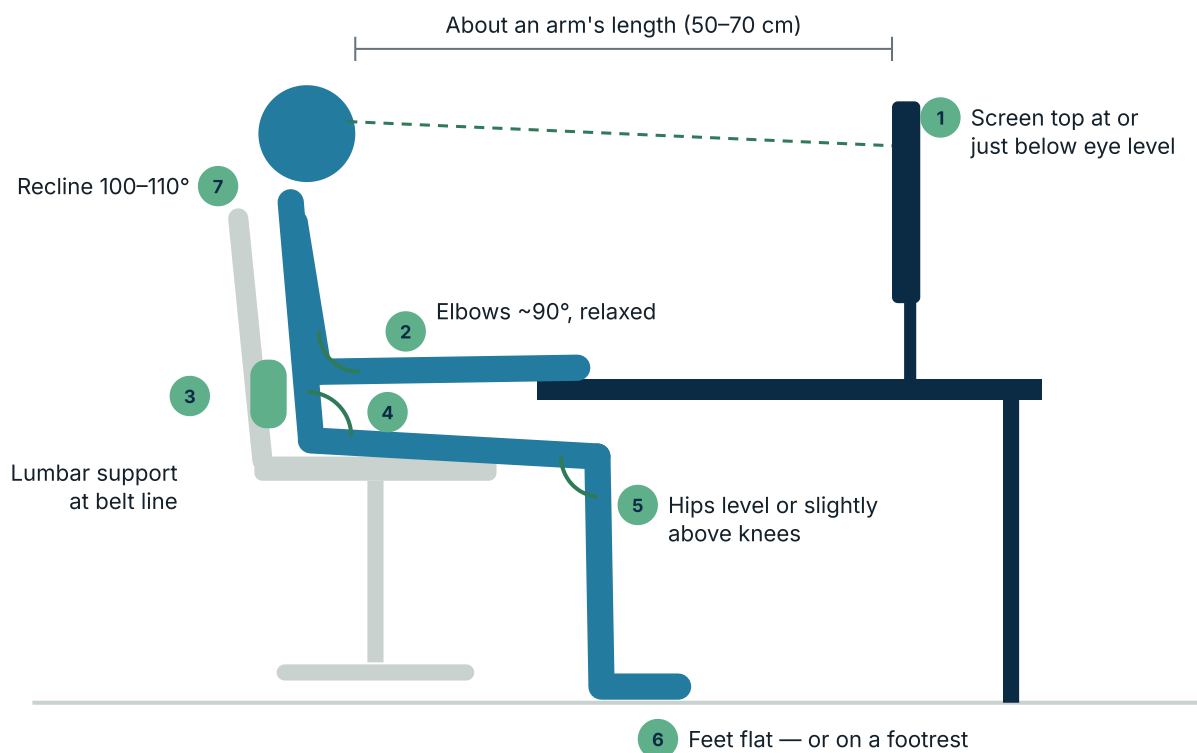
Cost

Usually nothing.
Books, a rolled towel
and a box fix most
setups.

Your chair, desk and screen decide the posture you fall into when you stop thinking about it. Set them up once, and good posture becomes the default instead of a daily battle.

The Ideal Desk Setup

Side view. Adjust in this order: chair → desk → screen.



(1)

Screen

Top edge at eye level, about an arm's length away.

(2–4)

Arms & back

Elbows near 90°, shoulders relaxed, lower back supported.

(5–7)

Legs & recline

Hips level or above knees, feet flat, recline 100–110°.

Setup Audit

Tick as you go



ELEMENT	TARGET	QUICK FIX
☐ Chair height	Feet flat, thighs roughly level	Add a footrest or box
☐ Lumbar support	Fills the gap at your belt line	Rolled towel or cushion
☐ Seat depth	2–3 fingers behind the knees	Cushion behind your back
☐ Desk height	Elbows at or just above desk	Raise chair, add footrest
☐ Screen height	Top edge at eye level	Stack books under it
☐ Screen distance	About an arm's length	Push it back
☐ Keyboard & mouse	Close, wrists straight	Bring them to the desk edge
☐ Lighting	No glare on the screen	Angle the screen from windows

Your score

___ / 8 ticked

Goal: 8 / 8

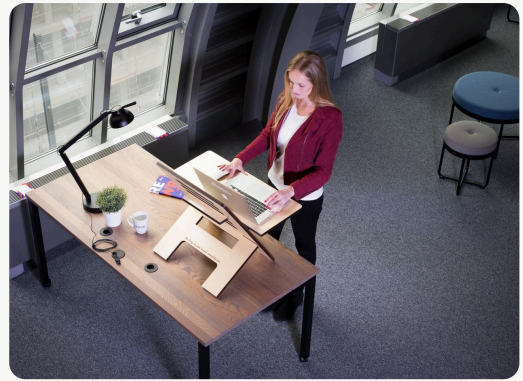
WORKING FROM A LAPTOP?

A laptop can't be ergonomic on its own: either the screen or the keyboard is always wrong. A stand plus a separate keyboard fixes both.

EYES COUNT TOO

Every 20 minutes, look at something 20 feet (6 m) away for 20 seconds. Your neck relaxes when your eyes do.

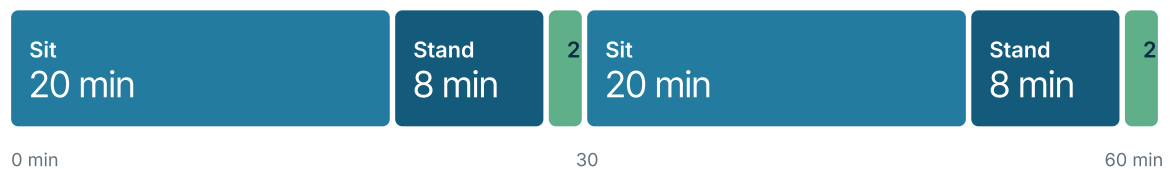
Sit. Stand. Move.



Standing all day isn't the answer either. The goal is variety. Use this simple 30-minute rhythm as a starting point.

The 20-8-2 rhythm

Every 30 minutes



Sit

20 min

Supported, upright, feet flat.

Stand

8 min

Calls, reading, email triage.

Move

2 min

Walk, stretch, refill water.

NO STANDING DESK?

TRY THIS INSTEAD

Phone calls

Take every call standing or walking

Meetings

Stand for the first 5 minutes of each video call

Water

Use a small glass so you refill more often

The 20-8-2 pattern is widely attributed to Cornell University ergonomics guidance; treat it as a starting point, not a rule.

The Hour-by-Hour Blueprint

One normal workday



07:00	WAKE	Wake-up mobility 3-minute routine before your phone: cat-cow, hip circles, reach.
-------	------	---

08:45	START	Setup check 30 seconds: chair, screen, feet. Fix whatever drifted.
-------	-------	--

10:30	AM	First movement snack 2 minutes: chin tucks, shoulder rolls, standing back bend.
-------	----	---

12:30	LUNCH	Walk after eating 10–15 minute walk. Eat away from your desk.
-------	-------	---

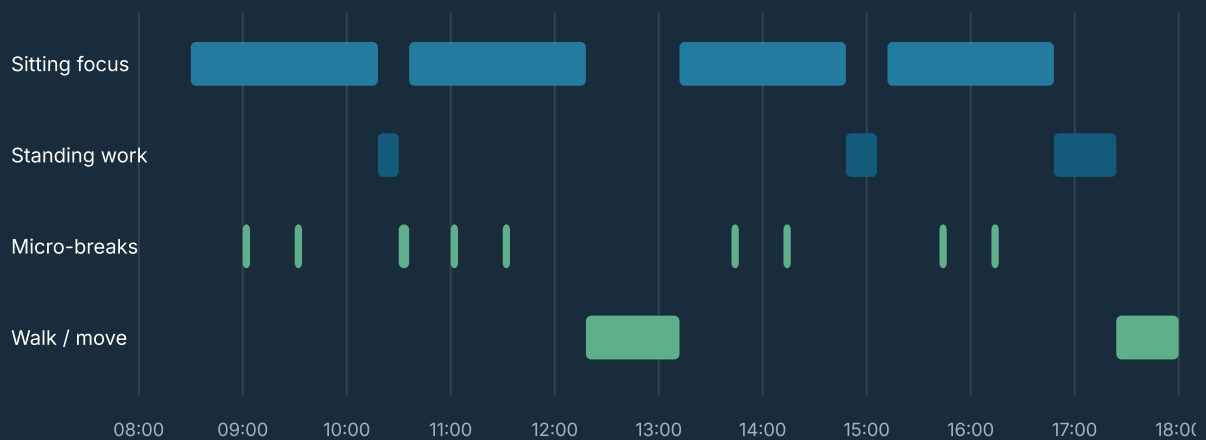
15:00	SLUMP	Afternoon reset Hip-flexor stretch + wrist routine. Hardest hour for posture.
-------	-------	---

17:30	CLOSE	Decompress The 10-Minute Back Reset (page 20).
-------	-------	--

21:30	NIGHT	Wind-down Neck release, heat if stiff, pillow check.
-------	-------	--

Your Day, Visualised

08:00 – 18:00



Longest single
sit

30m

Micro-breaks

9+

Standing time

~1h

Extra walking

20m+

MAKE IT AUTOMATIC

Set a repeating 30-minute timer, or link breaks to things that already happen: every sent email batch, every finished call, every coffee refill.

Stack the Habits

New habits stick when you attach them to something you already do. Pick three pairs from this table.

WHEN I...	I WILL...	TIME
Boil the kettle	Do 10 chin tucks	30 s
Open my laptop	Check chair, screen and feet	30 s
Finish a meeting	Stand and do 5 back bends	45 s
Send a big email	Roll my shoulders 10 times	20 s
Visit the bathroom	Do a doorway chest stretch	30 s
Brush my teeth at night	Do 10 calf raises	30 s
Total	6 tiny habits	≈ 3 min



Rule of thumb

Too small to skip

If a habit feels like effort, make it smaller. Five chin tucks you actually do beat twenty you skip.

Micro-Break Library

Under 60 seconds each



(01)

30 s



Chin tuck

1. Sit tall, eyes level.
2. Glide your chin straight back, making a double chin.
3. Hold 3 s, release. Repeat 10×.

(02)

20 s



Shoulder rolls

1. Lift shoulders to your ears.
2. Roll them back and down.
3. Repeat 10× slowly.

(03)

30 s



Standing back bend

1. Stand, hands on lower back.
2. Gently lean back, looking up slightly.
3. Hold 2 s. Repeat 5×.

(04)

40 s



Wrist flexor stretch

1. Arm straight, palm up.
2. Gently pull fingers back with the other hand.
3. Hold 20 s each side.

(05)

60 s



Seated figure-4

1. Cross ankle over opposite knee.
2. Sit tall and lean forward slightly.
3. Hold 30 s each side.

(06)

30 s



Calf raises

1. Stand holding the desk.
2. Rise onto your toes, lower slowly.
3. Repeat 15x.

BUILD YOUR 2-MINUTE BREAK

Pick any three moves from this library. Rotate them through the day so every hotspot gets attention.

READY-MADE COMBO

MOVES

BEST FOR

The Reset

01 · 02 · 03

Mid-morning slump

The Typist

02 · 04 · 01

Heavy keyboard days

The Unfold

03 · 05 · 06

After long meetings

Neck & Shoulders



5 minutes · twice daily



(01)

10 reps



Chin tucks

1. Sit or stand tall.
2. Glide chin straight back.
3. Hold 3 s, slowly release.

(02)

2 × 20 s



Upper-trap stretch

1. Right hand under your seat.
2. Tilt left ear to left shoulder.
3. Switch sides.

(03)

2 × 30 s



Doorway chest opener

1. Forearms on a door frame.
2. Step through gently.
3. Feel the stretch across your chest.

(04)

8 reps



Wall angels

1. Back and head against a wall.
2. Slide arms up in a 'W' to a 'Y'.
3. Keep your lower back flat.

WEEK	CHIN TUCKS	STRETCH HOLDS	WALL ANGELS
1	10	20 s	6
2	12	30 s	8
Goal	15	30 s	10

The 10-Minute Back Reset



Choose your level



Starter

Stiff, new to exercise

Cat-cow ×8

Knee rocks ×10

Child's pose 30 s

6 min

Standard

Most desk workers

Cat-cow ×10

Glute bridge ×12

Bird-dog ×8/side

Child's pose 45 s

10 min

Strong

Active, no current pain

Cat-cow ×10

Bridge ×15, hold 3 s

Bird-dog ×10/side

Side plank 3 × 20 s

Dead bug ×10

12 min

(01)

12 reps



Glute bridge

1. Lie on back, knees bent.
2. Squeeze glutes, lift hips.
3. Lower slowly over 3 s.

(02)

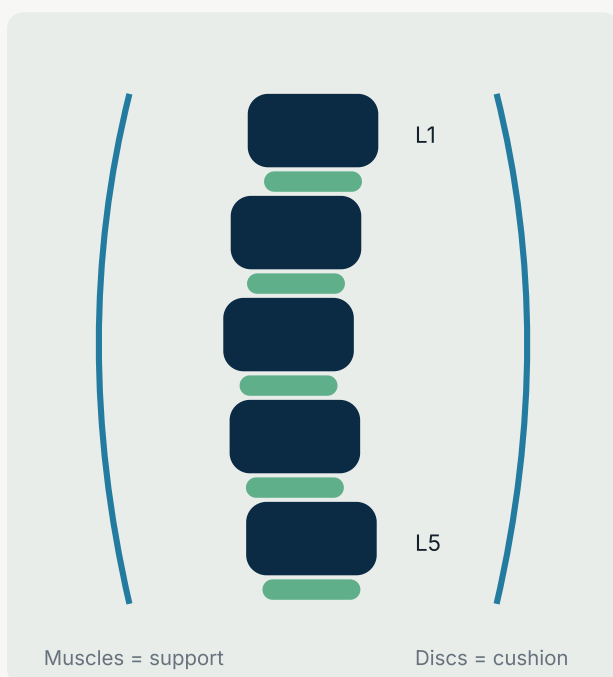
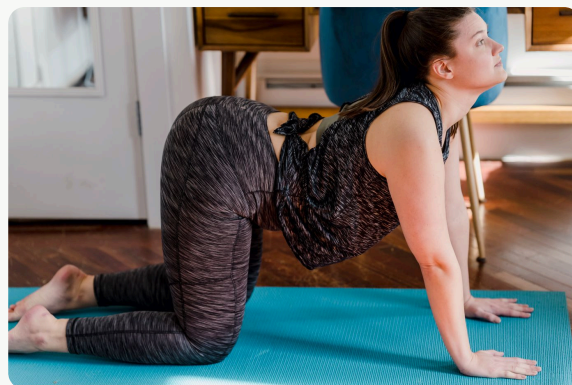
8 / side



Bird-dog

1. On hands and knees.
2. Reach opposite arm and leg.
3. Keep hips level; hold 2 s.

Why the Reset Works



(001)

Mobility

Cat-cow and knee rocks gently move each spinal segment after hours in one shape.

(002)

Strength

Bridges and bird-dogs wake up the glutes and deep core muscles that sitting switches off.

(003)

Control

Slow, controlled reps teach your back to stabilise under everyday load.

Sessions / week

5+

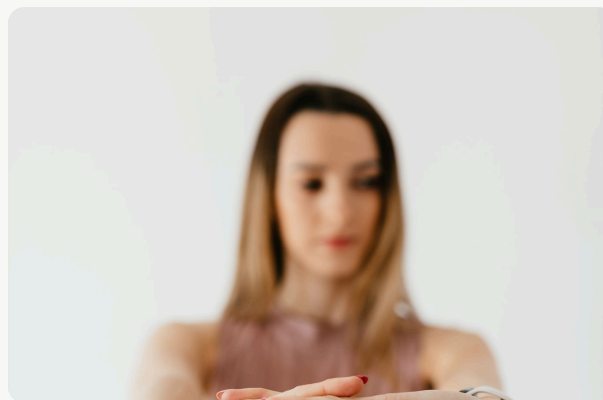
Time / session

10 min

Noticeable change

2-4
wks

Wrists & Hands



3 minutes · after long typing



(01)

2 × 20 s



Prayer stretch

1. Palms together at chest.
2. Lower hands, keep palms pressed.
3. Stop at a gentle stretch.

(02)

2 × 15 s



Reverse prayer

1. Backs of hands together.
2. Fingers pointing down.
3. Lift elbows gently.

(03)

5 cycles



Tendon glides

1. Straight fingers → hook fist.
2. Full fist → flat fist.
3. Move slowly through each.

(04)

10 reps



Fist-to-spread

1. Make a soft fist.
2. Spread fingers wide.
3. Repeat, both hands.

NEUTRAL WRIST RULE

Your hand should line up with your forearm when typing, not bent up, down or sideways. Lower the keyboard feet if needed.

MOUSE TIP

Move the mouse from your elbow, not your wrist, and keep it right next to the keyboard.

Routine D

Hips, Knees & Legs



6 minutes · end of day



(01)

2 × 30 s



Half-kneeling hip-flexor stretch

1. One knee down on a cushion.
2. Tuck pelvis, squeeze back glute.
3. Shift forward gently.

(02)

10 reps



Sit-to-stand

1. Sit near the chair edge.
2. Stand up without using hands.
3. Lower slowly over 3 s.

(03)

12 / side



Seated knee extensions

1. Sit tall.
2. Straighten one knee fully.
3. Hold 2 s at the top.

(04)

10 / side



Hamstring floss

1. Sit tall, one leg straight.
2. Point and flex the foot.
3. Lean forward slightly.

Hip flexors shortened while seated

All day

Knee-friendly

Low impact

Pair with

Evening walk



Recovery at Home

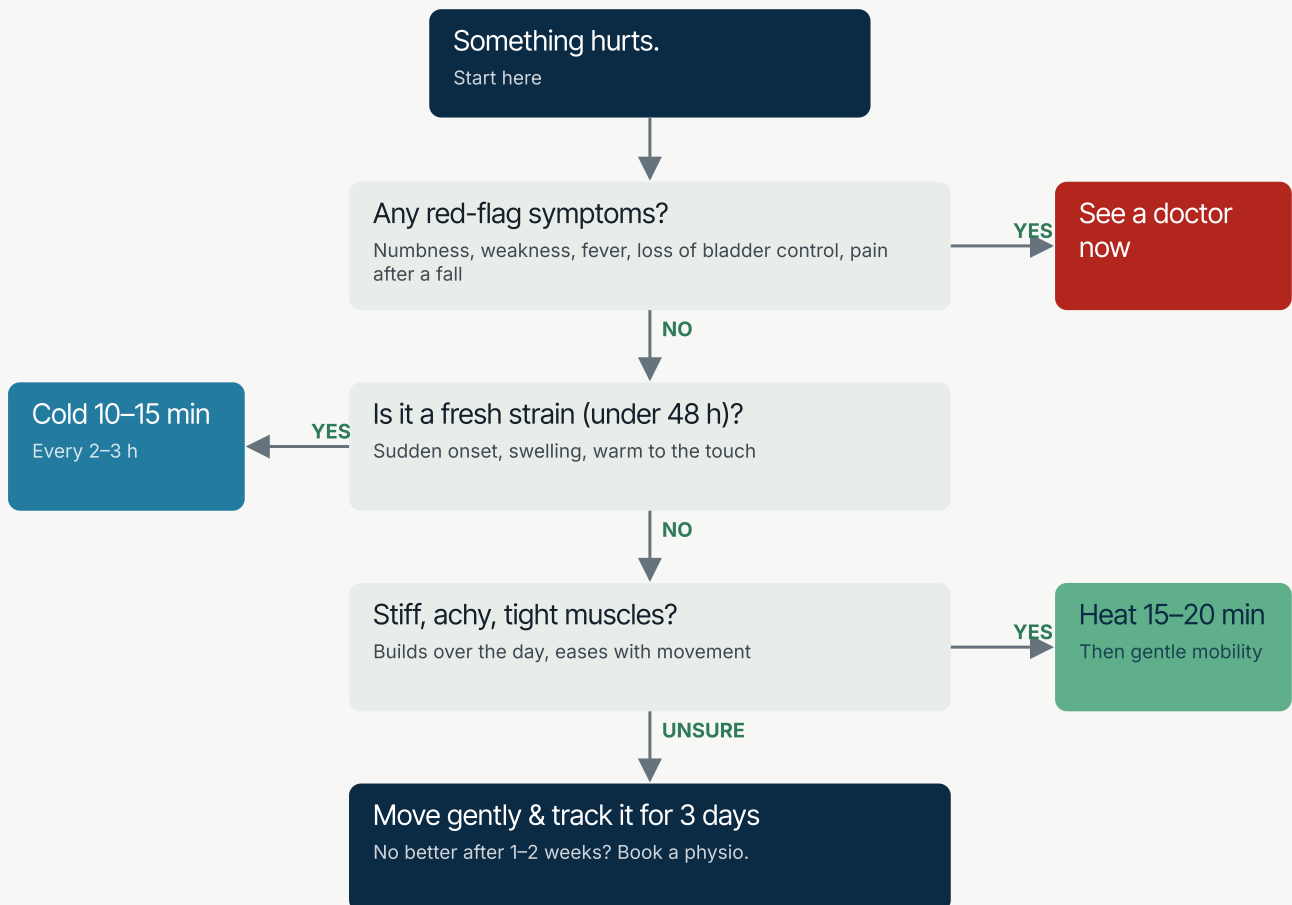
Heat vs. cold



	HEAT	COLD
Best for	Stiffness, tight muscles, chronic aches	Fresh strains, swelling, flare-ups
How it helps	Relaxes muscles, increases blood flow	Numbs pain, may reduce swelling
Duration	15–20 minutes	10–15 minutes
Timing	Before movement, or evenings	First 48 hours after a strain
Avoid when	Area is swollen, hot or bruised	Poor circulation or numbness
Golden rule	Always use a cloth layer between skin and the heat or cold source.	

What Should I Do?

Decision guide



This flowchart is a general guide only. When in doubt, especially if pain is severe, spreading or getting worse, get checked by a professional.

Sleep Without the Stiff Neck



Pillow height guide ☐

The goal is simple: keep your neck in line with the rest of your spine. The right pillow height depends on how you sleep.

Side sleeper
High & firm — fills shoulder gap

Back sleeper
Medium — supports the neck curve

Stomach sleeper
Very low — or none at all

Bedroom checklist

- ✓ Pillow height matches your sleep position
- ✓ Mattress doesn't sag in the middle
- ✓ Phone away 30 min before bed
- ✓ Room cool, dark and quiet

5-minute wind-down

- ✓ Chin tucks ×10, lying down
- ✓ Knee rocks ×10
- ✓ Heat on neck or back if stiff
- ✓ 3 slow breaths, 4 s in / 6 s out

POSITION	PILLOW	EXTRA SUPPORT
Side	Fills the gap between ear and mattress	Pillow between the knees
Back	Supports the neck curve, head not pushed forward	Pillow under the knees
Stomach	Very thin, or none	Thin pillow under the hips
Test	Lying down, your nose should line up with the centre of your chest.	

Your Recovery Toolkit



Movement comes first. Supports and recovery tools are there to make the good habits easier, not to replace them.

Back support

(001)

Lumbar Support Belt

Firm, adjustable compression for long shifts, lifting and commuting.

Wear for tasks, not all day

Neck & sleep

(002)

Neck & Sleep Support

Keeps the neck aligned overnight so you wake up less stiff.

Pair with the wind-down

Knee support

(003)

Heated Knee Massager

Soothing heat and vibration before movement or after a long day.

15–20 min sessions

Recovery

(004)

Recovery Tech

Targeted muscle relief for shoulders, back and legs after activity.

Light pressure, keep moving

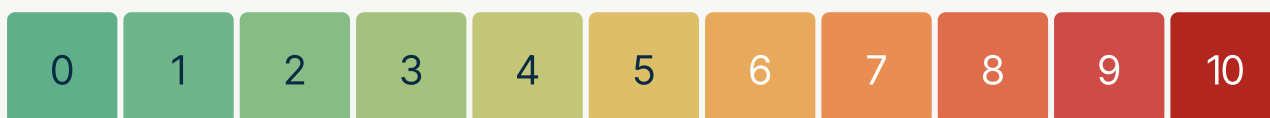
HOW TO USE A SUPPORT BELT WELL

Use it during demanding tasks such as lifting, long drives or long shifts, and keep doing the strengthening routines on pages 19–22 so your own muscles do more of the work over time.

Shop the full range in the MotionPluse online store.

Listen to the Signals

Pain scale 0–10



0–2 · Keep going

Normal stiffness, carry on

3–5 · Modify

Reduce range, go slower

6–10 · Stop

Rest; seek advice if it persists

RED FLAGS: SEE A DOCTOR PROMPTLY

- Numbness or tingling in the groin or buttocks
- Loss of bladder or bowel control
- Weakness in a leg or arm
- Pain after a fall or accident
- Fever or unexplained weight loss with back pain
- Severe pain at night that doesn't ease

Good signs

Stiffness that eases as you move.
Pain that settles within 24 hours of exercise. Gradually better mornings.

Ease off if

Pain rises above 5, lasts more than a day after a routine, or spreads down an arm or leg.

Your 14-Day Plan

Two weeks · 10 min a day



Day 01

Setup
audit +
Micro-
break 01

Day 02

20-8-2
rhythm
starts

Day 03

Back
Reset:
Starter

Day 04

Neck
routine A

Day 05

Back
Reset:
Starter

Day 06

Walk 20
min

Day 07

Rest +
wind-
down

Day 08

Back
Reset:
Standard

Day 09

Wrist
routine C

Day 10

Back
Reset:
Standard

Day 11

Hips
routine D

Day 12

Back
Reset:
Standard

Day 13

Longer
walk 30
min

Day 14

Review +
re-audit

Week 1 focus

Awareness

Week 2 focus

Strength

Total time

~2.5 hours

Habit Tracker

Printable

Tick a box each day you complete the habit. Aim for 5 of 7 rows by the end of week two.

Habit	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
Setup check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Micro-breaks (6+)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
20-8-2 rhythm	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10-min routine	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Walk 15+ min	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Screen at eye level	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Wind-down routine	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Daily score	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7	/7

Week 1 target

3+ habits / day

Week 2 target

5+ habits / day

Reward

Pick yours:

Progress Journal

Printable

Each evening, rate your stiffness or pain from 0–10 and plot it. The dashed line shows what a typical improving trend can look like.



DAY	WHERE?	SCORE	WHAT HELPED / WHAT HURT?
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

Cheat Sheet

EVERY 20 MIN

Look 6 m away for 20 s

EVERY 30 MIN

Stand + move for 2 min

EVERY HOUR

Chin tucks + shoulder rolls

EVERY LUNCH

Walk 10–15 min

EVERY EVENING

10-Minute Back Reset

EVERY NIGHT

Pillow check + wind-down

SETUP IN ONE LINE

Feet flat · hips $\geq$ knees · back supported · elbows 90° · screen at eye level, arm's length away.

Five Things to Remember

(01)

Your next posture is your best posture

Change position often. No position is perfect for eight hours.

(02)

Set up once, benefit daily

15 minutes of desk adjustments removes hours of strain.

(03)

Snack on movement

Two minutes every 30 minutes beats one hour at the gym on its own.

(04)

Strength protects

Ten minutes of glutes and core, five days a week, supports your back.

(05)

Know when to get help

Red flags or pain that won't settle deserve a professional's eyes.



Move better. Feel better.

A thank-you from us ☐



Your reader discount

10% off

your first order of supports and recovery tools

Use code

BLUEPRINT10

Shop

The MotionPluse online store

Questions

Reply to the email this guide came in.

Share

Know a desk worker who's sore?
Forward this guide.

